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E-Commerce vs. Brands: A serious conflict?

Brands recently released advisories against buying products on popular e-commerce sites. How does it impact the e-commerce segment? What does the e-commerce industry think? And most importantly, what does it mean for us buyers?

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Earlier this year, brands such as Lenovo and Toshiba warned customers against purchasing their products from e-commerce sites such as Snapdeal, Flipkart and Amazon India. The companies in their advisories said that Snapdeal, Flipkart and Amazon India are not the authorised resellers of their products. Recently, Gionee also released a similar advisory, warning not to purchase their products from any online retailers.

Such advisories from the companies, stressing on not buying products from e-commerce sites, come amid a wide push to the e-commerce segment in India. Most of the e-commerce sites are heavily focussing on electronic gadgets including smartphones and tablets. In fact, ASSOCHAM's paper on "Online Shopping - Review & Outlook in 2013" says electronic gadgets market was the third largest contributor to the e-commerce growth in India.

Therefore, advisories against e-commerce sites certainly creates a state of confusion, and to some extent discourages online shopping. We analyse the stand of these companies.

Let's take a look at the statements from Lenovo and Toshiba on the issue:

"What we have noticed in the past few months is that some of these sites, and largely due to a marketplace kind of a set up, there are a lot of resellers that have cropped up, which are selling at very low

predatory prices. These we believe may or may not be an authorised or genuine products," Sudhin Mathur, Director, Smartphones, Lenovo India is quoted as saying.

"Toshiba India does not have any direct arrangement with e-commerce websites, and they are not authorised to represent about the quality or fitness of any Toshiba-branded product," said a Toshiba in a statement to The Hindu.

Interestingly, camera giant Nikon had issued a similar statement last year:



To buy, or not to buy, that is the question

"Please note that e-commerce websites like Flipkart (Flipkart Internet Private Limited) and Snapdeal (Jasper Infotech Private Limited) are not our authorized partner/dealer in India, we advise you to check the warranty entitlements while buying from online portals."

Creating panic?

Though advisories from these brands seem to protect customers' interests, it certainly creates a state of confusion.

"The advisory issued by smartphone brands is definitely in the interest of consumers. But we oppose the smartphone brands' stand because through

this action they are alienating an entire channel and creating a certain amount of panic. A forum needs to be created between online retailers, offline retailers and brands to address this particular issue," says Mehul Jobanputra, CEO and Co-Founder of DesiDime.com.

As pointed out earlier, brands have especially cautioned customers about 'warranty' when purchasing their products online. However, e-commerce sites have categorically said that they sell genuine products which are eligible for warranty.

In an interaction with Digit, a Snapdeal spokesperson said: "Snapdeal.com is an online marketplace where authorized sellers list their products on the platform. We take utmost care to list products only by those sellers who have the necessary authorization to sell these products. These authorized sellers already selling offline are the ones listed on our site and are selling Lenovo and

Gionee products online through our platform. Customers can rest assured that all the products including Lenovo and Gionee products which are available on Snapdeal.com are genuine and eligible for warranty. Further, being an online marketplace, the pricing decision solely lies with the seller listing the product."

"The concern regarding the warranty of products sold is warranted. A consumer will be a repeated customer of the brand when he/she feels that the brand is assuring him/her of the product quality. So we completely support the concern raised for the warranty of products sold online. After sales service is as important